

Trump elevates attacks on the media

President and allies pounce with lawsuits as legacy outlets face loss of trust, influence.

By MEG JAMES

President Trump has long needed news outlets that got under his skin.

He branded CNN and others “fake news.” He repeatedly railed against journalists as the “enemy of the people” during his first term — rhetoric that news groups tried to shrug off or wore as a badge of honor.

But six weeks into Trump’s second administration, the attacks have carried a greater sting. In a recent rant on social media about MSNBC, Trump accused the liberal news network of being “an illegal arm of the Democratic Party.” He took direct aim at the network’s parent, Comcast, and its chairman, Brian Roberts, calling him a “lowlife.”

“They should be forced to pay vast sums of money for the damage they’ve done to our Country,” Trump wrote.

Presidents frequently skirmish with the press. Richard Nixon famously waged a pitched battle, placing several journalists on his notorious “enemies list.” But Trump’s broadsides have reached new heights, and media companies have scrambled to respond.

Some have raced to reset relations. To settle a lawsuit Trump brought early last year against ABC News and anchor George Stephanopoulos, Walt Disney Co. agreed to contribute \$15 million to a Trump presidential library, plus \$1 million for Trump’s legal fees.

Mark Zuckerberg’s Meta contributed \$25 million to end a beef that began after Trump was booted from Facebook for his words and actions preceding the deadly Jan. 6 Capitol riots. Trump sued Facebook in 2021, alleging free speech violations.

CBS owner Paramount Global has been racked for weeks over whether to settle Trump’s \$20-billion lawsuit over edits to a “60 Minutes” interview, a suit that 1st Amendment experts say is frivolous.

The Associated Press went to federal court to reverse a ban of its journalists after the White House barred the news service for declining to adopt Trump’s name for the Gulf of Mexico — the Gulf of America.

“The press and all people in the United States have the



JESSICA MILLER cries in front of her destroyed art studio and home along East Palm Street in Altadena on Feb. 4.

‘The stress keeps you up at night’

Emotional devastation lingers in L.A. fire zones, a poll of voters shows

By HAILEY BRANSON-POTTS

For weeks after the Eaton fire ravaged her Altadena home, Ivana Lin lived in a constant, overwhelming state of fight or flight.

Her body was tense. She barely slept. At one point, she jotted down a to-do list of everything she felt pressure to get done in one day — including itemizing her lost belongings for her insurer, applying for financial assistance and figuring out child care for her 4-year-old son whose preschool burned.

The list had 50 tasks. “The stress keeps you up at night,” said Lin, 38, who had lived with her hus-



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times
CHAPLAINS from Samaritan’s Purse pray with residents at their Sunset Avenue home.

band in Altadena since 2017. “You feel like you’re never done. ... We wake up at 3 or 4 in the morning. Do as much as we can. Fall asleep around midnight.”

Chris Russo, who had closed escrow on a house in Pacific Palisades one day before the Palisades fire burned it down, said it has “been a full-time job to manage how to recover from this disaster.”

Russo, who had lived in West Hollywood for 24 years, thought she had found her paradise: a single-wide trailer in the Tahitian Terrace mobile home park across the street from Will Rogers State Beach.

“Honestly, it was magical,” she said. “Now, I have to pivot.”

[See Emotional, A7]

Malibu shops face fire’s economic toll

Businesses have been suffering as PCH travel difficulties keep customers away.

By JAMES RAINEY

Two months after twin fires destroyed large swaths of two Southern California communities, many of the businesses left behind are struggling to revive sales in the face of displaced customers, road closures and a massive rebuilding effort that is projected to drag on for years.

The secondary crisis has hit hard in Malibu because of the ongoing closure of Pacific Coast Highway to most vehicle traffic — isolating the beachside community

from customers coming from the Westside.

Some businesses have closed and others say they are struggling to stay open. Sales for some restaurants and shops have plummeted to less than half what they were before the Palisades fire roared through the east end of the city in early January.

Leaders in the city government and business community have urged the state transportation agency, Caltrans, to expand access to PCH. But with the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers only about to begin clearing hundreds of destroyed homes along the highway, the crucial coastal route seems likely to remain as a choke point for months and possibly years.

[See Malibu, A8]



PAUL KURODA For The Times
MICHAEL AUSTIN pets one of his 18 cats at his makeshift home at a Fremont encampment. A new city law bans encampments, in line with a Bay Area trend.

Turmoil in a Bay Area city over anti-encampment law

Fremont is the latest struggling to balance homeless services with safety concerns.

By HANNAH WILEY

FREMONT, Calif. — Dominating one corner of a sprawling homeless encampment on an abandoned lot next to Fremont’s rumbling BART tracks, Michael Austin has built his own kind of palace.

His makeshift home — a tent fortified with wood paneling, steel poles and chain-link fencing — rises two stories high, with a daybed on the first floor and a queen mattress on the second, plenty of cushioning for his 18 cats to get cozy. He’s built a fire pit out front, and planted a long pole in the middle of camp to fly the American flag. Scattered throughout his camp, along with piles of dried cat food, is an assortment of tools, scrap metal and motor gear that Austin, 60, transforms

into mini go-karts, motorized bikes and scooters.

His 20 or so neighbors camping on the lot at Osgood Road and Washington Boulevard live in a grim assortment of tents, tarps and plywood.

Normally, Austin said, he likes to keep his space in a state of organized chaos. But lately he sees no point in tidying up. Any day now, he expects orders to pack up and move from the lot he’s called home for two years. A new city law bans encamp-

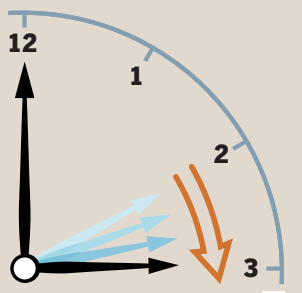
[See Fremont, A11]

Eyewitnesses recount the horrors in Syria

Clashes in the country’s coastal areas have killed more than 700 people, a monitor says. **WORLD, A3**

Why isn’t Bass saving her texts?

None remain from time of Palisades fire start and Ghana trip, city says. **CALIFORNIA, B1**



Timely reminder
Daylight saving time began Sunday at 2 a.m.

The search for a perfect martini

Our restaurant critic goes on a quest. Cheers, **L.A. WEEKEND, L6**

Weather
Lots of sun.
L.A. Basin: 73/48. **B10**

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